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II

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THE TEL HAROR INSCRIPTION AND CRETE: A FURTHER LINK

The presence of Minoans and Mycenaeans (the intended 'Aegeans' of this conference) in the East and the West of the Aegean Sea and its confines is an old tale, at least as old as the Homeric epics. Ancient authors, like Strabo, assumed that myths, such as the ones referring to the Argonauts, hinted at the quest for metals (gold, in particular).¹ Excavation results from the East and the West of the Aegean have come to confirm these old stories: pottery is the most telling witness (to the degree that when it's absent, it is almost upsetting for the excavator), and other representatives of material culture have been detected here and there. It is obvious that the reason for the movement of people and objects has been some kind of product exchange, the exact nature of which is being fervently debated.

Until relatively recently no written records were known to have accompanied the Bronze Age 'Aegeans' in their travels -assuming it was them who travelled to the East and the West, and not vice versa. Correspondence of official as well as private character is well known from the Near and Middle East, and Egypt: although Egyptians remain undetectable in the archaeological record of international correspondence, since they were probably dispatching papyrus rolls, the opposite seems to have been the case with Syro-Palestinian and Alashiyan (west Cypriot, now) rulers, who sent their cuneiform tablets to Amarna in the 14th century.² Nothing comparable to the Amarna letters has ever been found relating to the Aegean, and the scripts that flourished there in the 2nd mill. BC. The scraps of written evidence we have at our disposal indicate the presence of 'Minoans' in the North Aegean and on the Asia Minor coast. In the first instance, some written (in either the Cretan Hieroglyphic or Linear A) and stamped documents were retrieved on the island of Samothrace, in a site (Mikro Vouni) that otherwise shows minimal material evidence of Minoan presence;³ in the second case, Miletus is the site which has yielded evidence of local knowledge of the Linear A script; local use of this writing system is nonetheless accompanied by a set of evidence 'minoanising' to such a degree, that allows the excavator to suggest the establishment of a Minoan colony there.⁴

The Samothrace and Miletus finds represent two different phases in Minoan history. The Samothrace trip is placed in the Protopalatial period, whereas the Miletus adoption of the Linear A script fits well into the latest Neopalatial phase during which this script seems to enjoy a certain popularity among the Cycladic islands (Thera, Kea, Melos) and the SE Peloponnese (Ag. Stefanos, Kythera). The character of the finds in the two cases is of very different nature, and so seems to have been the character of Minoan presence in the respective locations, which are situated so far away from the Minoan homeland.

The only relatively secure evidence so far of any kind of exportation of a Minoan script outside the Aegean milieu came from the Near East.⁵ A pithos fragment with pre-firing incised

1 O. LORDKIPANIDZE, "The golden fleece: myth, euhemeristic explanation and archaeology," *OJA* 20 (2001) 1-38.

2 Y. GOREN, S. BUNIMOVITZ, I. FINKELSTEIN & N. NA'AMAN, "The location of Alashiya: new evidence from petrographic investigation of Alashiyan tablets from el-Amarna and Ugarit," *AJA* 107 (2003) 233-56; Y. GOREN, I. FINKELSTEIN & N. NA'AMAN, "The expansion of the kingdom of Amurru according to the petrographic investigation of the Amarna tablets," *BASOR* 329 (2003) 1-11.

3 D. MATSAS, "Samothrace and the Northeastern Aegean: the Minoan connection," *Studia Troica* 1 (1991) 159-179. Also: D. MATSAS, "Minoan long-distance trade: a view from the Northern Aegean," in *POLITEIA* 235-247, pls. XXXIV-XXXVIII. Also, in *CMS* V.S3.

4 B. & W.-D. NIEMEIER, "The Minoans of Miletus," in *MELETEMATA* 543-554, pl. CXVII-CXX.

5 As far as the Tel Lachish inscription is concerned (M. FINKELBERG, A. UCHITEL & D. USSISHKIN, "A Linear A inscription from Tel Lachish (LACH Za 1)," *Tel Aviv* 23 [1996] 195-207), see J.-P. OLIVIER, "Rapport 1996-2000 sur les textes en écriture hiéroglyphique crétoise, en linéaire A et en linéaire B," in *Proceedings of the 11th International Mycenological Colloquium, Austin-Texas, May 8th-12th 2000* (forthcoming).

script signs was found in the site of Tel Haror in the Negev desert and is dated by the excavator in MBA III (or IIC), i.e. in the late 17th or early 16th cent. BC⁶ (Pl. CXCVIIIa). The pot sherd originated from a handmade pithos, from which it was broken already in ancient times, and no other sherds of the same pot were found in the vicinity: these are the reasons why the excavator suggested that it might have served as an *ex-voto* to a building interpreted as a temple (a 'migdal') at Tel Haror. We have to add at this point that petrographic analysis established the Cretan provenance of the sherd, and to be more exact, from the area of Myrtos Pyrgos in the south coast of the island of Crete:⁷ it is one of these rare happy occasions when the epigraphic data match the archaeological record.

The sherd bears an inscription consisting of three signs either in the Cretan Hieroglyphic script or in Linear A. The editor of the inscription, J.-P. Olivier, does not consider it a genuine inscription, but a *graffito*, because the signs are not of the same size, they are not aligned, and they do not have the same orientation; for these reasons, he suggests that we are probably dealing with logograms, which represent commodities, and not with syllabograms. The presumed logograms represent commodities, notably 'FIG', 'TELA+TE', and a bull's head, with all probability a *rhyton*. It is preferable, however, to call the total of these signs an *inscription*, since it fits the -now- classic definition given by the same editor, i.e. a minimum of 2 signs.⁸

The site of Tel Haror in the Negev

But, what is the site where the sherd was found and which is the context of the find? Tel Haror⁹ is situated in the western Negev desert, 20 km east of Gaza and Tell el-Ajjul, and is being excavated since 1982 by a mission of the Ben-Gurion University of the Negev. The lower city extends to an area of 40 acres, and like a number of neighbouring sites, it is fortified: ramparts and a deep moat surround it. The rampart was never crowned by a wall: rather it seems to have fallen out of use shortly after it was constructed and was then replaced by a massive wall. Excavations within the fortified area revealed a large MB III palatial building with stone foundations and massive piers at regular intervals; the excavator sees a Syrian prototype in the inspiration of this building and he mentions the palaces (although of a different scale) at Alalakh, Mari and Tell Mardikh (Ebla).

In the southern slope of the tell, in area K, a building complex was excavated, which comprised a massive building termed as a 'migdal,' a 'fortress' sanctuary, and auxiliary structures (storage and workshops facilities) around a courtyard. The features of the building, which led to its terming as a cultic space, are an offering altar, surrounding repositories, offering stands (as incense burners), miniature votive vessels, zoomorphic vessels, animal and human figurines. Additionally, an equine burial in a pit in the courtyard and the faunal material collected in the building suggest the rearing of animals for slaughtering, as well as the ritual killing of puppies.¹⁰ OED suggests that an 'ex-voto' means "an offering made in pursuance of a vow" and in view of the character of the building where the inscription was found (a cult space) it is understandable how the excavator arrived at such a conclusion.

6 E.D. OREN, J.-P. OLIVIER, Y. GOREN, P.P. BETANCOURT, G.H. MYER & J. YELLIN, "A Minoan graffito from Tel Haror (Negev, Israel)," *Cretan Studies* 5 (1996) 91-118. In J.-P. OLIVIER, "Rapport 1991-1995 sur les textes en écriture hiéroglyphique crétoise, en linéaire A et en linéaire B," in S. DEGER-JALKOTZY, S. HILLER & O. PANAGL (eds), *Florent Studia Mycenaea. Akten des X. Internationalen Mykenologischen Kolloquiums in Salzburg vom 1.-5. Mai 1995* (1999) 419-435, the date given is 1700-1600/1550 BCE, probably for the whole of Syro-Palestinian MBA III (p. 430).

7 P.M. DAY, E.D. OREN, L. JOYNER & P.S. QUINN, "Petrographic analysis of the Tel Haror inscribed sherd: seeking provenance within Crete," in *MELETÉMATA* 191-6, pl. XXXIX.

8 J.-P. OLIVIER, "Les sceaux avec des signes hiéroglyphiques. Que lire ? Une question de définition," *CMS Beiheft* 1 (1981) 108.

9 The information on Tel Haror is found in articles by its excavator: E.D. OREN, "Tel Haror," in E. STERN (ed.), *The New Encyclopedia of archaeological excavations in the Holy Land* (1993) 580-584; OREN *et al.* (*supra* n. 6); E.D. OREN, "The 'kingdom of Sharuhen' and the Hyksos kingdom," in E.D. OREN (ed.), *The Hyksos: new historical and archaeological perspectives* (1997) 253-283.

10 J.D. KLENCK, *The Canaanite cultic milieu: the zooarchaeological evidence from Tel Haror, Israel (2000-1500 BC)* (2002) [non vidi].

Apart from the architectural and material culture evidence, what we need to keep in mind is that as far as the site is concerned we are dealing with a period of early urbanisation in the region: not many settlements seem to have existed in the vicinity before the MB II period. Tel Haror itself is founded on a tell that was sparsely inhabited before MBA II (or IIB), and the construction of the fortification seems to have been undertaken along with the establishment of the settlement. The excavator favours maritime trade as the cause for an establishment of settlements in the Mediterranean coastal area, although there seem to be more settlements inland than there are on the shore. A further note on the economy of these MBA settlements in Southern Syro-Palestine at the period is their seemingly close relationship with the Egyptian culture in terms of exchanges and trade.

The Tel Haror inscription in the framework of the Aegean scripts

It is true that looking at the Tel Haror inscription from the 'Aegean' point of view there is a number of odd traits. As far as the epigraphic part is concerned, peculiarities are already noted in the publication of the inscription: discrepancy in the size of signs, a form of the 'FIG' sign that is rare, a ligatured logogram otherwise not attested exactly as such in neither Linear A or the Cretan Hieroglyphic, and finally, a sign depicting the horned head of an animal, which looks more like a drawing rather than the usual minimal and schematic script signs.

A further difficulty comes from the fact the sherd, for which an absolute date is given, cannot be placed with certainty within Aegean absolute chronology: if we choose the early or 'high' chronology, the sherd corresponds to the end of LM IA,¹¹ but if we choose the late or 'low' chronology, the transition of MM IIIB-LM IA seems to correspond to the sherd in question.¹² No matter which is the date concerned here, the pithos is presumed to be of Middle Minoan date according to the excavator,¹³ and it should be viewed in any case as an heirloom from either a distant Minoan past, or a more recent.¹⁴ The purpose of this paper is nonetheless to insert the inscribed sherd in the Aegean scripts framework and to establish what, if anything, can be said on the nature of the inscription and its primary purpose.¹⁵

Since we are dealing with an inscription that was inscribed sometime in the Middle Minoan period, we should be looking at both the Cretan Hieroglyphic and the Linear A scripts corpora. It is a well-known fact, inasmuch as it remains a constant problem for research, that for the greater part of the MM period the two scripts co-existed in Crete, at times in the same deposits. The Tel Haror inscription becomes part of the problem from the moment that the editor himself acknowledges the difficulty in assigning it to one script or the other. The challenge would therefore be to find some kind of connection between this inscription and the written record in Crete. The signs as such have their parallels, as already demonstrated by the editor. But, what about this particular sequence of signs?

The only answer to this question comes, strangely enough and rather unexpectedly, from the Cretan Hieroglyphic seals material: the same three signs, as these can be seen on the Tel Haror inscription, seem to be repeated on a seal face, although not in the same order. The seal

11 S. MANNING, *A test of time: the volcano of Thera and the chronology and history of the Aegean and east Mediterranean on the mid second millennium BC* (1999). For a slight revision of the date suggested in *A test of time* (1628 BC), see C.U. HAMMER, G. KURAT, P. HOPPE, W. GRUM, & H.B. CLAUSEN, "Thera eruption date 1645BC confirmed by new ice cor data," in M. BIETAK (ed.), *The synchronisation of civilisations in the eastern Mediterranean in the second millennium B.C. II, Proceedings of the SCIEEM 2000 EuroConference, Haindorf, 2nd of May-7th of May 2001* (2003) 87-94, where c. 1665-1598 is suggested.

12 P. WARREN, "LM IA: Knossos, Thera, Gournia," in *MELETEMATA* 893-903, pl. CCVI-CCVII. Also: C.F. MACDONALD, "Review article: Chronologies of the Thera eruption," *AJA* 105 (2001) 527-532.

13 OREN (*supra* n. 9, 1997) 271.

14 For a fine distinction between 'souvenirs,' 'antiques' and 'heirlooms,' see VAN WIJNGAARDEN in this volume. It is difficult to place the Tel Haror sherd under any of van Wijngaarden's models, simply because we cannot be certain when and how the pithos or this single sherd was brought in Tel Haror. The word 'heirloom' was chosen here as the one which bears fewer connotations than 'souvenirs' and 'antiques.'

15 Following the lines of thinking of the sherd's editor, who distinguished a primary purpose (when the inscription was drawn on the pithos) and a secondary one (when the sherd bearing it was brought to the temple) (OLIVIER in OREN *et al.* [*supra* n. 6] 109).

is the unique bone 4-sided 'bar'¹⁶ found in the eastern rooms of the burial Building 6 in Fourni in Archanes, along with 15 more seals and a scarab.¹⁷ The seal has all together 14 faces (3 faces on each long side of the 'bar,' and a further 2 faces on each of the short sides), and this makes it unique in terms of shape among the Cretan seals in general.

Two of the seal faces (H and I) bear the so-called 'Archanes formula:' this 'formula' is a total of two sign-groups, which consist of 2 and 3 signs each (Pl. CXCVIIIc). The seals that bear the 'formula,' as well as a number of other seals that appear to belong to the same style-group, were somewhat misleadingly termed by Yule as the 'Archanes script' style-group: it is probably perceived at times to be a different script, other than the Cretan Hieroglyphic or Linear A, and notably before them; yet, the 'Archanes formula' seals seem to fit in very well with the Cretan Hieroglyphic seals, and one of the reasons why they might appear different or strange is their early date (MM IA).¹⁸

In view of the fact that the seal contains these two sign-groups that are usually considered to belong to the Cretan Hieroglyphic script corpus,¹⁹ it was included in CHIC and a second drawing of this seal was executed (Pl. CXCVIId).²⁰ The only two faces which finally do appear in CHIC are the ones bearing the 'Archanes formula;' the face we are interested in (G) was not included in the final version of CHIC, although the motifs on it can qualify as script signs and the whole as an inscription. Also, the rest of the faces were not included, since they bear isolated motifs, and they can by no means qualify as inscriptions in the (editors') strict sense. The *apparatus criticus* nonetheless notes: "'Signes' possibles en G (·?·?·?); 'signes' isolés en J (008) et en L (010)." The drawings of the faces not included in CHIC in the end can be seen in Pl. CXCVIIf.²¹

Face G is found on the same side as the 'Archanes formula' inscription, and the seal faces on their turn seem to be organised according to the logic of sides (faces A-C: quadrupeds). Furthermore, this seal is very closely related with writing in Crete, and the Cretan Hieroglyphic script, to be more precise: faces J and L bear isolated Hieroglyphic signs 008 (a 'hand') and 010 (a 'leg') respectively, and it seems that from wherever the seal engraver was copying his inscriptions from, more script signs existed than we finally see before us. The seal face does not give us any indication as to the direction of reading of the inscription, which is therefore arbitrary: 'TELA', 'FIG' and an animal's head. After personal inspection of the seal cast in the CMS archive in Marburg, and with the help of some more expert eyes, it seems that one of the motifs, notably the one that appears on the right hand side of the face, is on such a badly corroded part of it, that its recognition is highly doubtful.²²

It seems that almost the same set of signs is involved in both inscriptions. Of course, the fact that they are found in a different order makes a possible identification of one with the other precarious. Also, the fact that the seal inscription seems to contain a plain textile representation and not a ligatured logogram, such as the one that appears to be attested in the Tel Haror inscription, could be seen as a further obstacle.

Yet, the Tel Haror inscription provides us with a clue, which can be used to the benefit of reading the inscription: the animal's head stands out from the rest of the inscription by virtue of its size and alignment, whereas the other two signs are of the same size and aligned. The fact that we are in a position to isolate one of the signs gives us a hint as to interpreting this

16 The term taken from P. YULE, *Early Cretan seals: a study of chronology* (1980) 100 (seal subclass 34a). CMS II.1, 391.

17 G. SAKELLARAKIS & E. SAPOUNA-SAKELLARAKI, *Αρχάνες. Μια νέα ματιά στη μινωική Κρήτη*, v. I-II (1997) 103, fig. 79.

18 For a lengthier discussion of this complicated topic, see A. KARNAVA, *The Cretan Hieroglyphic script of the second millennium BC: description, analysis, function and decipherment perspectives* (unpubl. Ph.D. thesis, Free University of Brussels 2000) 195-8.

19 For the suggestion that these seals should be viewed as belonging to the Linear A script, see L. GODART, "L'écriture d'Arkhanès: hiéroglyphique ou linéaire A?", in *MELETEMATATA* 299-302.

20 J.-P. OLIVIER & L. GODART, *Corpus Hieroglyphicarum Inscriptionum Cretae* (avec la collaboration de J.-Cl. Poursat) (1996) (quoted as CHIC). The drawing was executed by L. Godart.

21 It was provided to me by J.-P. Olivier, with the kind permission of the draftsman and co-editor of CHIC, L. Godart.

22 Dr. Ingo Pini might even say not distinguishable at all (pers. comm.).

sign as a logogram. If we choose to accept this sign as a logogram, and the remaining two as syllabograms, on account of the fact that they are found together and unified, then the Tel Haror inscription reads as follows: animal's head (logogram), 'TELA+TE'-'FIG' (sign-group). The seal inscription gives us nonetheless no evidence that we should treat any of the signs in a different way, but once the animal's head in the Tel Haror inscription is viewed as a logogram, then both inscriptions appear more compatible.

Discussion

Initially, what has to be said about the Archanes seal in question is that it is dated to the late prepalatial period, namely MMIA.²³ This element on its own raises a problem for the beginning of writing in Crete, which is not of our concern here. What concerns us however is that all we have as script testimonies from this early period is a series of seals bearing the 'Archanes formula,' a formula which is not repeated in any other Cretan Hieroglyphic inscribed objects -other than seals- of later date. We do have evidence nonetheless that this formula states something comprehensive and intelligible over time, because seals with this formula are used in Samothrace to seal clay sealings in the MM II-[III] period;²⁴ a late use of earlier seals cannot be suggested, because an agate cushion (of unknown precise find-spot) bears the formula;²⁵ hard stone cushions in general seem to appear in MM II and continue into LBA.²⁶

The above observations about the 'Archanes formula' do not however apply equally smoothly to the Tel Haror inscription: we can only suggest a continuous use of the (almost) same inscription if we are prepared to accept a function for this inscription similar to the 'Archanes formula.' At the moment, and due to the limitations imposed by the paucity of the material, we are not justified in advocating any such thought.

As far as the primary purpose of the inscription is concerned we are still very much in the dark. Regardless of whether the Tel Haror signs are in fact logograms or syllabograms, we have before us an unorthodox situation: the absence of numerals always leaves us clueless as to the purpose of the inscription, since we are dealing with an undeciphered inscription.

As far as the secondary purpose of the inscription is concerned, it has been suggested that the sherd constituted some kind of offering to a sacred place. The presumed 'sanctity' however of the find-spot does not automatically preclude a commercial side to the transportation of the pot or the sherd. The old debate, about who and with what means of justification was responsible for the movement and exchange of goods, seems most of the times to forget that the limits between 'sacred,' 'powerful' and 'prestigious' are never as clear-cut as archaeologists would like them to be. A reminder of how mundane a 'sacred' environment could be is the 'migdal' itself: the sanctuary is lined along with storage spaces and workshops around a courtyard.

The excavator's observation that this was the only sherd retrieved from the original pitthos, a comment used to reinforce his suggestion on the 'sacred' character of the sherd, is not inexplicable in archaeological terms. The sherd was earlier called an 'heirloom':²⁷ if

23 SAKELLARAKIS & SAPOUNA-SAKELLARAKI (*supra* n. 17). In vol. II, the MM IA period is clearly defined as the latest prepalatial phase (p. 394-405). In vol. I, p. 327, the Hieroglyphic seals from Archanes are dated in EM III-MM IA, whereas in vol. II, p. 674-691, they come under the general heading "EM III-MM IIA seals (2300-1750 BC)." More detailed studies of the Archanes prepalatial seals list them under "Phase 3" (an internal division of the Archanes seals, in A. KARYTINOS, "The stylistic development of seals from Archanes-Phourni throughout the prepalatial period-Style and social meaning," *CMS Beiheft* 6 [2000] 123-134), or under "late MM IA/MM IB" (a division based on the stratigraphical sequence, in K. SBONIAS, *Frühkretische Siegel. Ansätze für eine Interpretation der sozial-politischen Entwicklung auf Kreta während der Frühbronzezeit* [1995] 63-70). Both studies agree that it is the latest prepalatial phase one deals with, regardless of its name.

24 POURSAT in *CHIC*, p. 30. More recently: Matsas, in *CMS* V.S3 suggests MM IIIA.

25 *CMS* VII, 35 (*CHIC* #205).

26 YULE (*supra* n. 16) 45-6.

27 *Supra* n. 14.

it was brought in at the time it was manufactured (MMII period), what we would expect in a stratum of a later date is exactly an isolated sherd, like so many isolated sherds of earlier date are so frequently found in later strata. On the other hand, if it was brought in at a time contemporaneous with the stratum in which it was found, then is there a better chance that the pithos was not brought in complete.

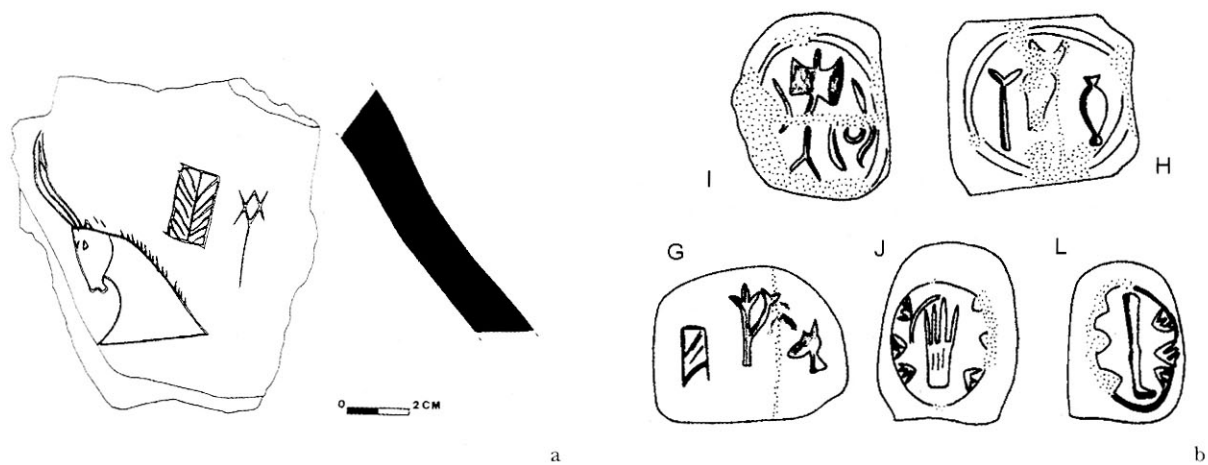
A final note should be devoted to the find-spot and the wider area, Syro-Palestine in the beginning of the second millennium. The sherd is found in a seemingly non-literate milieu, which makes its presence all the more unexpected and incomprehensible. It is true that we are talking about a period when contacts between the Levantine coast and Egypt, which is ruled by the (Hyksos) 15th dynasty, are particularly strong; further SW of the area that concerns us (but not virtually far, if we are willing to accept the role of Sinai as an active bridge for the tight links between Egypt and Syro-Palestine, as suggested by Oren), the proto-Sinaitic inscriptions are also dated at the end of the MBA; at the same time, from the East and the North the cuneiform influences are there, but none of the surrounding writing systems is adopted or used in any way (it will be some time before Ugarit creates its own version of the cuneiform script, the cuneiform alphabet). It is, on the other hand, the same area, broadly speaking, that has produced the earliest 'alphabetic' inscriptions, the so-called 'archaic' Canaanite inscriptions on an *ostrakon* from Gezer and a dagger from Tel Lachish, dated around 1600 BC.²⁸ At the present state of affairs, we would be in no position to suggest who would be interested in receiving an inscribed sherd in that part of the world, or what they would think of it. We can suggest however, as a closing remark, that the Aegean scripts should be counted among the writing systems present in the neighbourhood of the area that prompted the invention of the alphabet.

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28 É. PUECH, "Origine de l'alphabet," *Revue Biblique* 93 (1986) 161-213, esp. 195-6.

LIST OF ILLUSTRATIONS

- Pl. CXCVIIIa The Tel Haror inscribed sherd (from OREN *et al.* [*supra* n. 6] 91-118, fig. 1a).
Pl. CXCVIIIb The 8-sided bone seal from Archanes (drawing by L. Godart: sides I and H are published in *CHIC*, 290-1, as #315).
Pl. CXCVIIIc The "Archanes formula" transcribed (*CHIC* #315).
Pl. CXCVIId The 8-sided bone seal from Archanes (*CMS* II.1, 391; taken from *CHIC* #315).



I 042-019
H 019-095-052

« Signes » possibles en G (•?-•?-•?) ; « signes » isolés en J (008) et en L (010).

